

The Letter of Peter to Philip

Codex Reference: VIII,2

Translated by: Marvin W. Meyer and Frederik Wisse

Source: Robinson, J.M. (ed.), *The Nag Hammadi Library in English*, 3rd rev. ed. (HarperSanFrancisco, 1990), p. 431ff.

Editor's Introduction

Introduced by Marvin W. Meyer

Translated by Frederik Wisse

The Letter of Peter to Philip fills most of the concluding nine pages of Codex VIII. Situated immediately after the tractate Zostrianos, The Letter of Peter to Philip opens with a superscribed title (132,10-11) derived from the letter which forms the first part of the tractate. Like several other tractates in the Nag Hammadi library (Ap. Jas., Treat. Res., Eugnostos), The Letter of Peter to Philip is presented, in part, as a letter. Besides these letters in the Nag Hammadi library, other letters were also in use among the Gnostics (for example, Ptolemy's Letter to Flora, and letters of Valentinus, Monoimus the Arabian, and perhaps Marcion). Furthermore, just as a magnificent epistolary tradition developed around Paul and the Pauline school, so also a more modest collection of letters came to be ascribed to Peter. These Petrine or pseudo-Petrine letters include, in addition to The Letter of Peter to Philip, the catholic letters of Peter in the New Testament, the *Epistula Petri* ("Epistle of Peter") at the opening of the Pseudo-Clementines, and perhaps another letter of Peter known only from a brief quotation in Optatus of Milevis. Of these letters the pseudo-Clementine *Epistula Petri* is of special interest, since it shares a number of features with The Letter of Peter to Philip. Not only is it prefixed to a collection of materials relating to Peter; it also seeks to attest the authority of Peter, and as it concludes, the *Contestatio* begins by referring to the recipient—James the Just—reading and responding to the letter in a manner like that of Philip in the Letter of Peter to Philip 133,8-11. The Letter of Peter to Philip, however, is not to be identified with any of these letters attributed to Peter and must represent a newly discovered work in the Petrine corpus.

In its present form The Letter of Peter to Philip is clearly a Christian Gnostic tractate. Taken as a whole, the tractate is to be seen as a part of the Petrine tradition: Peter is the leader, the spokesman, the preacher among the apostles, and he may very well be described as having his own disciples (139,10). The only other apostle mentioned by name is Philip, who is submissive to the authority of Peter and whose place in the tractate seems intended to highlight the pre-eminent authority of Peter. With their leader, Peter, the apostles gather at Olivet and are taught by the risen Savior; upon returning to Jerusalem, they teach in the temple and perform healings; and eventually they go forth to preach, filled with holy spirit. In other words, not only the place of Peter but also the scenario of the narrative would suggest that The Letter of Peter to Philip shares important features with part of the first (Petrine) section of the Acts of the Apostles (chapters 1-12).

That the author of The Letter of Peter to Philip makes use of Christian traditions cannot be doubted. In particular, numerous parallels between this tractate and the first half of the Acts may be noted, including scenes, themes, and terms which are similar to these two documents. Even

the genre of literature they represent—a narrative on Peter and the apostles within which are included revelatory, liturgical, and edificatory materials—is similar, although in the case of The Letter of Peter to Philip the narrative has been prefixed with a letter of Peter. Furthermore, the author of The Letter of Peter to Philip is familiar with other Christian traditions besides Lukan materials. The Savior’s second revelatory answer (136,16-137,4) resembles the Johannine Logos hymn (Jn 1:1-18), but the similarities must not be overdrawn. Again, the traditional kerygmatic formulae in the credo of the sermon (139,15-21) show affinities with similar formulae to be found throughout early Christian literature (the parallels in John 19 are particularly close to the credo in The Letter of Peter to Philip), and the little “Pentecost” of The Letter of Peter to Philip (140,1 [?]-13) shares features with the Johannine “Pentecost” account (20:19-23). Moreover, the author of this tractate also mentions previous revelatory utterances of the Savior (135,5-6; 138,2-3, 22-24; 139,11-12), utterances frequently said to have been given while Jesus was embodied. Presumably these revelations of the embodied Savior could refer to such teachings as are presented in the canonical gospels, and the “four words” of 140,25 could have been understood as the four gospels to be sent to the four directions. (Hans-Gebhard Bethge suggests that originally the text of 140,25 may have read “the four directions,” which eventually could have been modified to read “four words.”) Hence, it is clear that the author of The Letter of Peter to Philip is conversant with early Christian materials and desires to establish continuity with these earlier traditions.

Gnostic emphases are clearly visible in the narrative framework of The Letter of Peter to Philip. In particular this observation applies to the gnostic “dialogue,” the revelatory discourse of the Savior uttered in answer to the questions of the apostles. The first four revelatory answers (135,8-137,13) are at most marginally Christian, though they have been taken over and legitimated as revelations of the risen Lord. The first answer (135,8-136,15), which provides an abbreviated version of the myth of the mother, illustrates no overtly Christian features at all. It reflects a rather simple version of the myth, and is similar to the Sophia myth of The Apocryphon of John and the Barbelognostics of Irenaeus (Haer. 1.29.1-4) in terminology and general presentation. This set of four revelatory answers furnishes a gnostic perspective on the fall into deficiency and the attainment of fullness, and the imprisonment and the struggle of Gnostics in the world. To this set of answers has been appended an additional question and answer (137,13-138,3) which utilizes different terms and focuses upon the life and mission of the apostles. Gnostic in perspective like the other answers, this additional answer does show Christian concerns, and illustrates a dominant interest of The Letter of Peter to Philip, the suffering of the believer.

In addition to the questions and answers in the gnostic dialogue, other materials similarly used in the tractate may also show gnostic proclivities. The two prayers of the gathered apostles (133,17-134,9) contain traditional terms and themes commonly found in early Christian prayers, but also proclaim a luminosity and glory which make them especially appropriate as the prayers of Gnostic Christians. Likewise, the description of the resurrected Christ as a light and a voice (134,9-14; 135,3-4; 137,17-19; 138,11-13,21-22) represents a primitive way of depicting the appearances of the risen Lord (Mk 9:2-8 par.; 2 P 1:16-19; Ac 9:1-9; 22:4-11; 26:9-18; 1 Co 15; Rv 1:12-16), but among Gnostic Christians such theophanic descriptions were particularly appreciated.

In the brief sermon of Peter (139,9-140,1 [?]) gnostic tendencies are even more clearly seen. To be sure, a traditional Christian credo constitutes the first part of the sermon (139,15-21), and traditional terms are applied to Jesus ("the Lord Jesus," "the Son," "the author of our life"), but the credo is interpreted according to the Gnostic Christian theology of the author of The Letter of Peter to Philip. From the time of his incarnation Jesus suffered, but he suffered as one who is "a stranger to this suffering" (139,21-22). A Christological tension remains as the sermon stresses both the reality of Jesus' sufferings and the glory of his divinity. In contrast to the suffering illuminator Jesus, the sermon continues, the followers of Jesus suffer because of "the transgression of the mother" (139,23). This phrase is reminiscent of references to the fall of mother Eve, and refers, for the Gnostic Christian author, to the mother often named Sophia in other versions of the myth. She is also called "the mother" at 135,12, and her tragic fall is seen as the source of human sufferings. Hence, this reference to "the transgression of the mother" may provide another point of contact between the figures of Eve and Sophia in gnostic literature.

It is possible, then, to suggest a general outline for the literary history of The Letter of Peter to Philip. On the basis of the parallels with The Apocryphon of John and Irenaeus, we suggest that The Letter of Peter to Philip was written around the end of the second century C.E. or into the third. The author of the text presumably wrote in Greek: such may be intimated by the presence of Greek loan words and Greek idioms. The author apparently was a Christian Gnostic who was well versed in the Christian tradition, and who used and interpreted that tradition in a Christian Gnostic fashion. A gnostic dialogue has been constructed, though it is less a true dialogue than a revelatory discourse of Christ in answer to questions raised by the apostles. Within this dialogue are included gnostic materials which are non-Christian or only marginally Christian; these materials have been adopted as revelatory disclosures of the risen Christ. On the basis of the Christian and gnostic traditions with which the author was familiar, the author compiled a narrative document with a revelatory focus. The letter itself was added at the beginning of this narrative in order to stress the authoritative place of Peter, and The Letter of Peter to Philip subsequently received its present title. Finally, the Greek tractate was translated into Coptic, and found its way into Codex VIII of the Nag Hammadi library.

According to the reports of James M. Robinson and Stephen Emmel, another Coptic text of The Letter of Peter to Philip is to be found in a papyrus codex which, at the present time, is neither published nor available for study.